THE RAMBAM'S EIGHT CHAPTERS - SHEMONAH PERAKIM

What Stands Between a Prophet and God?

The Rambam's Eight Chapters, Chapter 7

Sefer: Shemonah Perakim (the Eight Chapters) by the Rambam **Chapter:** Chapter 7
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Tuesday-night series on the Shemonah Perakim, Tuesday 2 April 2024

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

This was the last class before Pesah. The Rabbi reviewed the chapters so far, ending with Chapter 6: for rational misvot a person should work to remove the desire itself, while for misvot known only through revelation it is fine to want the forbidden thing, and the only thing stopping us should be the will of Hashem. He shared that his daughter, who had overheard the previous class, walked past the smell of non-kosher food at a market and told him how good it smelled, quoting the shiur.

Veils of mind and character

Chapter 7 is about nevuah, prophecy. Hazal speak of prophets who saw Hashem from behind many veils (mehisot) or few, and of Moses who saw from behind one, and that one clear: he gazed through the aspaklaria hameirah, the shining mirror.

The Rambam explains: human perfection is of two kinds, of the intellect and of character, and so are human flaws. Flaws of character include excess desire, arrogance, anger, impatience, brazenness and the pursuit of money. Every one of these flaws is a veil between a person and God. As Isaiah said, "Your iniquities have separated between you and your God."

So a prophet must have all the intellectual virtues, but only most of the character virtues, together with the important ones. This is how the Rambam reads "Prophecy rests only on one who is wise, strong and wealthy": wise is intellectual perfection; strong is the one who masters himself; wealthy is the one content with his portion. The Rabbi noted that this is the Rambam's own understanding of prophecy, and promised to return to why prophecy matters so much to him.

Flawed prophets

The Rambam shows that we do not expect a prophet to be morally flawless, and the Rabbi asked the class to guess each flaw before reading it.

- **Shelomoh.** Hashem appeared to him in Givon, yet he had excess desire: many wives and great wealth.

- **David.** He was a prophet, yet he had a trace of cruelty. Even though he fought those who had to be fought, Hashem told him, "You shall not build a house for My name, because you have shed much blood." A participant cited the Midrash that his slain were like offerings on the altar. The Rabbi explained that the Rambam takes the verse literally: the killing was necessary, but perhaps it went beyond what was needed. Asked why the Rambam does not mention Bathsheba, the Rabbi said that was a single sin which David confessed and atoned for; the Rambam is speaking about traits, not one-off deeds.
- **Elijah.** He was too much of a zealot, too harsh with Israel, and Hashem told him to appoint a successor.
- **Shemuel.** When sent to anoint David he said, "Saul will hear and kill me." That fear shows a lack of trust in Hashem.
- **Yaakov.** "Yaakov was very afraid" of Esav.

The more of these traits a person has out of balance, the more veils. The Rabbi enjoyed how mechanically the Rambam describes something so lofty. He also pointed out that the Rambam lists traits (fear, impatience, cruelty), not deeds, which becomes important later.

Traits that stop prophecy completely

Some traits block prophecy entirely, even one alone.

- **Anger.** Hazal say that whoever becomes angry loses his prophecy. When Elisha grew angry with Yehoram, his prophecy left him, and he asked for a musician to restore it.
- **Worry and sadness.** In the twenty-two years Yaakov mourned Yosef, he had no prophecy. When he saw the wagons, "the spirit of Yaakov their father revived", which the Targum, followed by the Rambam, reads as the spirit of prophecy resting on him again. The Shekhinah rests only through joy, not through sadness or laziness.

Moses: seeing the back, not the face

After the golden calf, Moses won forgiveness and the return of the Shekhinah, and then asked, "Show me Your glory." Hashem answered, "You cannot see My face... you will see My back." Since God has no form, the Rambam explains: Moses had reached such perfection that he asked to grasp God's very essence. The only veil left was that his intellect was still in a body. That could not be removed while he lived.

Seeing a face means knowing someone so clearly that his image is fixed in your mind. Seeing someone's back from a distance, you know who it is, but you could not draw him. The Rabbi compared it to seeing someone on a Zoom screen versus standing in front of him. Moses received a little less than full knowledge.

The Rambam promised to explain more in a book on prophecy. He wrote this commentary in his early twenties; that book was never written, and its contents went into the Moreh Nevuchim instead.

The Rabbi then read the story of Miriam and Aaron speaking against Moses. Between their complaint ("Has Hashem spoken only through Moses?") and Hashem's rebuke sits the verse "The man Moses was very humble, more than any person." It is the key: Moses's moral

perfection set him apart, so prophecy is not a single threshold that puts all prophets on one level.

Can anyone be like Moses?

Since every prophet must already reach full intellectual perfection, the differences between prophets must lie in character. But the Rambam writes elsewhere that every person can become a saddik like Moses. Then why "there has not arisen a prophet in Israel like Moses", which we sing in Yigdal?

The Rabbi's answer goes back to Chapter 2. A person can perfect his actions (faculty two) and his intellect to the level of Moses. Translating that into his very essence, his will (faculty four), as Moses did, is something no one else will fully achieve. That is why the Rambam spoke of the prophets' traits and not their deeds. "A monkey can do actions." Misvot that do not change who we are miss their purpose.

Prophecy today, and three views

Can someone be a prophet today? The Gemara says prophecy ceased after the destruction of the Temple. The Rabbi explained the Rambam's reading: it is not that prophecy was switched off. Prophecy needs a constant spiritual joy, the elation of the Temple service with its music and offerings, and since the destruction that level of joy is almost unreachable. He compared it to the rare spiritual high some feel at Neilah.

He then read from the Moreh Nevuchim on three views of prophecy:

1. Hashem chooses whomever He wishes, wise or not. The Rabbi said the Rambam is referring to the view of the Kuzari, and that Albo held similarly.
2. The philosophers: prophecy is a natural human perfection; whoever prepares properly must become a prophet.
3. The Torah's view, which agrees with the philosophers except on one point: even a fully prepared person may be withheld from prophecy by God's will.

So for the Rambam the miracle is not who receives prophecy but who, fully prepared, does not. Since prophecy is a process, the Rambam held that a non-Jew can also attain it, unlike the Kuzari. Intellectual perfection, for the Rambam, includes the theoretical sciences as well as Torah, which is very hard in an age of specialists.

A question: Jeremiah was told "Before you were born I chose you", while Avot and the Gemara in Sotah, the basis of the Ramhal's Mesillat Yesharim, describe climbing step by step to prophecy. The Rabbi said Hashem knew where Jeremiah would reach. He added that not every prophet carries a message to the people; that mission is a separate choice made after a person reaches prophecy.

Summary

- Every intellectual and moral flaw is a veil between a person and God; Moses had none left but his body.
- A prophet needs full intellectual perfection and most good middot; anger and sadness block prophecy entirely.

- Anyone can become a saddik like Moses in deeds; making it his whole essence is beyond any other person.
- Prophecy ceased with the Temple because the joy it requires became almost unattainable.
- For the Rambam prophecy is earned through preparation, open even to non-Jews, though God may withhold it.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/qHZkXOZsv3E · More shiurim: rabbikada.com